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THE ARIZONA POST

Sports In Review

Algerian Champ In Ring-Lights Jewish Quiz Box

By HAROLD U. RIBALOW

At this time of year, we weigh and judge the accomplishments of the past year, but we must not overstate or overestimate what has been done. This is a time for truth-telling. And so, in discussing the Jewish sports scene, we must point out that this has been a year of mixed blessings.

Jews did fairly well in the Olympic Games, and now they are involved in the Israel Maccabiah. Quite apart from the results of these games, we cannot help but be impressed by the vast number of Jewish

athletes from all over the world.

IN THE UNITED STATES, the sports activities of Jews have been lessening in some fields and holding on in others. In boxing, for example, once a domain in which Jews excelled, there is one major personality Alphonse Halimi, who gained the bantamweight championship of the world. A predecessor was Robert Cohen. Halimi is an Algerian Jew, as was Cohen.

In the United States there are no Jewish fighters of note, although a past champion Barney Ross, has man-

aged to remain in the spotlight. A film based on his career was released all over the world, and Ross has a knack for winning newspaper space with his various opinions, on boxing and on life in general.

Baseball, our national game never did boast of many Jewish stars at a single time, even though there have been a large number of Jewish diamond stars. This past season one new star emerged. He is Sandy Koufax, the Brooklyn Dodger left-hander, whose blazing fastball made him a strikeout artist. As Koufax is only 21 years old, he has an excellent opportunity to become a major league star. Oddly enough, while there have been a few score Jewish ball stars, few indeed have won prominence as pitchers. Sandy Koufax has a chance to do that.

ANOTHER FAMILIAR name has cropped up in baseball, following years of com-

parative obscurity. He is Andy Cohen, who used to be a Giant second baseman in the late 1920's. Cohen has been knocking about in the minor leagues as a manager and is still doing the same sort of work. But now he is in the American Association, with Indianapolis, one of the high-ranking minors.

IN PROFESSIONAL basketball, which finally came into its own last year, there was only one Jewish star: Dolph Schayes of Syracuse, formerly of New York University. Schayes has gradually improved to the point where some basketball reporters think he is the very best in the game. In any event, he had a great year last season and remains as the only Jewish star in the pro game.

While there were lots of Jewish basketball players in college ranks, the only one who won all-American mention was Lennie Rosenbluth of North Carolina.

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Jewish Quiz Box

QUESTION: Why is it customary to refrain from sleeping on the afternoon of Rosh Hashanah?

ANSWER: Several reasons are offered for this tradition. Some quote a Rabbinic saying that "he who sleeps on Rosh Hashanah sleeps away his fortune." Some claim that sleeping on Rosh Hashanah afternoon is a sign of disinterest and apathy in the process of judgment. It is not fitting to sleep in the courtroom when the judge is presiding. Rosh Hashanah is the day of judgment and demands the courtesies due the process of justice.

Others claim that when a person is asleep his soul is entrusted to the powers on high. Having his soul in their power they are in a position to make a decision as to whether or not the individual is entitled to receive it back again. Staying awake causes a man to retain his soul and prevent the judgment from being passed upon it since one cannot pass judgment without the defendant being present.

QUESTION: Why is it customary to especially wear something new on the second night of Rosh Hashanah?

ANSWER: There is a difference of opinion among the early authorities as to whether the blessing of "Shehechiyonu" should be made when lighting the candles and making the Kiddush on the second night of Rosh Hashanah. In order to avoid the possibility of doing the wrong thing it became customary for the housewife to wear something new for the first time when lighting the candles on the second night of Rosh Hashanah. The male who makes Kiddush on the second night either wears something new or saves a new fruit, which he hasn't eaten this season yet, for this occasion, so that the new garment or new fruit would call for the blessing regardless of whether the second night of the festival does or does not.

QUESTION: Why is the shofar blown from the place where the Torah is read?

ANSWER: Two reasons are generally advanced for this requirement. First, this place is one upon which the concentration of the congregation is focused and centralized. Its original central location made it a point from which all could hear the Shofar. Secondly, sounding the Shofar from that point reminds us that the Shofar was sounded when the Torah was given at Sinai. The Shofar notes thus remind us of our responsibility to uphold the commandments and study the Torah.

QUESTION: Why does the Rabbi of the synagogue announce the name of each shofar note before it is blown by the appointed person?

ANSWER: This is done so as to make sure that the person who blows the notes blows the proper ones each time without any mistakes. The requirements for the notes and their order are involved with technicalities. It becomes the responsibility of the Rabbi to watch for those things and to help prevent mistakes from occurring and also to prescribe the proper procedure in case one is made.

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